THE NEW MBA PREMIUM

The MBA placement market is becoming more selective and fluid, with recruiters hiring earlier, looking beyond the traditional campus hierarchy, and paying a premium for candidates with demonstrable business skills

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FOR MBA STUDENTS, the old anxiety over placement day is giving way to a new uncertainty: where, when and how they get hired is changing. Even as the final placement remains a crucial milestone, companies are increasingly making their decisions over a longer period—through internships, live projects and pre-placement offers (PPOs), after getting a chance to see candidates in action.

And the change is not simply about fewer jobs or tougher placements. The latest placement data from the *BT*-MDRA Best B-schools Survey 2026-27 presents a more nuanced picture.

At the Top 25 B-schools, placements fell from 97.5% in 2025 to 96.4% in 2026. But at schools ranked 51–75, the placement rate jumped from 87.4% to 93.8%.

Even the internship market is shifting: average stipends at the Top 1–25 schools fell about 23%, while they rose 20% at schools ranked 51–75 and 11% at those ranked 76–100. PPOs, too, saw a decline, averaging 91 in the Top 1–25, down from 93 in 2025. In the Top 26–50, average PPOs fell from 35 to 31 over the same period.

What is emerging is a more fluid and selective MBA hiring market. Recruiters are widening the campuses they source from, and at the same time becoming more exacting about the roles they need and the candidates they want.

The premium is increasingly going to students who can demonstrate that they can solve a real problem—not simply those with the right degree or a prestigious campus on their CV. Companies, too, are becoming more selective about who they hire, what roles they hire for, and which skills they are willing to pay for.

The result is a placement market that is starting to assess candidates much before the formal placement season begins (through internships and live projects) — with domain expertise, AI readiness, and demonstrable impact increasingly determining who gets hired and at what price.

About 30–60% of MDI Gurgaon's hiring across domains would be through the PPO route, according to Rohit Sindhwani, Assistant Professor, Chairperson - Student Affairs and Faculty In-charge - GP Placements, who adds that the hiring mix is moving away from some core IT consulting roles towards